OBC, EWS AND SOCIAL MOBILITY

TWO ROUTES, TWO LOGICS → LAW BANK → LIST-MAKING LADDER → COMMISSION STATUS CARD → CREAMY-LAYER TEST → AMENDMENT AND JUDGMENT SEQUENCE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g1 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00 TWO ROUTES, TWO LOGICS

STAGE 00 · TWO ROUTES, TWO LOGICS · SOCIAL AND EDUCATIONAL BACKWARDNESS OR PURE ECONOMIC WEAKNESS · ROUTE A · ARTICLE 15(4) AND ARTICLE 16(4); LISTED CLASSES; 27 PER · ROUTE B · ARTICLE 15(6) AND ARTICLE 16(6); UP TO 10 PER · EVIDENCE A · COMMUNITY BACKWARDNESS; EVIDENCE B

DISADVANTAGE — social and educational backwardness OR pure economic weakness → ROUTE A: Article 15(4) and Article 16(4); listed classes; 27 per cent; creamy-layer filter → ROUTE B: Article 15(6) and Article 16(6); up to 10 per cent; excludes SC, ST → EVIDENCE A: community backwardness; EVIDENCE B: notified income and asset test → TEST — neither route supplies the other route's evidence or its filter

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- DISADVANTAGE → social and educational backwardness OR pure economic weakness
- ROUTE A: Article 15(4) and Article 16(4); listed classes; 27 per cent; creamy-layer filter

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- ROUTE B: Article 15(6) and Article 16(6); up to 10 per cent; excludes SC, ST and OBC
- EVIDENCE A: community backwardness; EVIDENCE B: notified income and asset test

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- TEST → neither route supplies the other route's evidence or its filter
- DISADVANTAGE → social and educational backwardness OR pure economic weakness

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TEST → neither route supplies the other route's evidence or its filter.

01 LAW BANK

STAGE 01 · LAW BANK · ARTICLE 15(4) AND 16(4) · SPECIAL PROVISION AND RESERVATION FOR BACKWARD CLASSES · ARTICLE 342A · CENTRAL LIST; PRESIDENT SPECIFIES; PARLIAMENT ALONE INCLUDES OR EXCLUDES · ARTICLE 338B · THE NATIONAL COMMISSION FOR BACKWARD CLASSES, INSERTED IN 2018 · ARTICLE 15(6) AND 16(6)

ARTICLE 15(4) AND 16(4) — special provision and reservation for backward classes → ARTICLE 342A — Central List; President specifies; Parliament alone includes or excludes → ARTICLE 338B — the national commission for backward classes, inserted in 2018 → ARTICLE 15(6) AND 16(6) — economically weaker sections, inserted in 2019 → STATUTE — National Commission for Backward Classes Act, 1993, later repealed

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- ARTICLE 15(4) AND 16(4) → special provision and reservation for backward classes
- ARTICLE 342A → Central List; President specifies; Parliament alone includes or excludes

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- ARTICLE 338B → the national commission for backward classes, inserted in 2018
- ARTICLE 15(6) AND 16(6) → economically weaker sections, inserted in 2019

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- STATUTE → National Commission for Backward Classes Act, 1993, later repealed
- ARTICLE 15(4) AND 16(4) → special provision and reservation for backward classes

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: STATUTE → National Commission for Backward Classes Act, 1993, later repealed.

02 LIST-MAKING LADDER

STAGE 02 · LIST-MAKING LADDER · STEP 1 · COMMUNITY BACKWARDNESS EXAMINED AGAINST SOCIAL AND EDUCATIONAL INDICATORS · STEP 2 · COMMISSION EXAMINES INCLUSION OR EXCLUSION REQUESTS AND ADVISES · STEP 3 · PRESIDENT SPECIFIES THE CENTRAL LIST UNDER ARTICLE 342A · STEP 4

STEP 1 — community backwardness examined against social and educational indicators

STEP 2 — commission examines inclusion or exclusion requests and advises → STEP 3 — President specifies the Central List under Article 342A → STEP 4 — Parliament alone varies that list by including or excluding a community

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- STEP 1 — community backwardness examined against social and educational indicators
- STEP 2 — commission examines inclusion or exclusion requests and advises

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- STEP 3 — President specifies the Central List under Article 342A
- STEP 4 — Parliament alone varies that list by including or excluding a community

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- PARALLEL — States prepare their own lists for State purposes after the 105th Amendment
- STEP 1 — community backwardness examined against social and educational indicators

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: PARALLEL — States prepare their own lists for State purposes after the 105th Amendment.

03 COMMISSION STATUS CARD

STAGE 03 · COMMISSION STATUS CARD · UNDER THE ACT OF 1993 DATED 2 APRIL 1993 · THE 1993 ACT, THROUGH THE REPEAL ACT OF 2018 · EIGHTH COMMISSION, 102ND AMENDMENT DATED 11 AUGUST 2018, ARTICLE · CHAIRPERSON, VICE-CHAIRPERSON AND THREE OTHER MEMBERS · SECRETARY TO THE GOVERNMENT OF INDIA; CONDITIONS NOTIFIED ON

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
CONSTITUTED — under the Act of 1993 dated 2 April 1993; reconstituted seven times to 2016	ELEVATED — eighth commission, 102nd Amendment dated 11 August 2018, Article 338B inserted	RANK — Secretary to the Government of India; conditions notified on 23 August 2018
REPEALED — the 1993 Act, through the Repeal Act of 2018 dated 14 August 2018	COMPOSITION — Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson and three other Members	CONSTITUTED — under the Act of 1993 dated 2 April 1993; reconstituted seven times to 2016

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- CONSTITUTED — under the Act of 1993 dated 2 April 1993; reconstituted seven times to 2016
- REPEALED — the 1993 Act, through the Repeal Act of 2018 dated 14 August 2018

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- ELEVATED — eighth commission, 102nd Amendment dated 11 August 2018, Article 338B inserted
- COMPOSITION — Chairperson, Vice-Chairperson and three other Members

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- RANK — Secretary to the Government of India; conditions notified on 23 August 2018
- CONSTITUTED — under the Act of 1993 dated 2 April 1993; reconstituted seven times to 2016

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RANK — Secretary to the Government of India; conditions notified on 23 August 2018.

04 CREAMY-LAYER TEST

STAGE 04 · CREAMY-LAYER TEST · LIMB 1 STATUS · NOTIFIED PARENTAL SERVICE AND STATUS CATEGORIES EXCLUDE THE APPLICANT · LIMB 2 INCOME · CEILING OF ₹8 LAKH APPLIED OVER THREE CONSECUTIVE YEARS · SALARY INCOME AND AGRICULTURAL-LAND INCOME ARE NOT SIMPLY CLUBBED · THE FILTER RUNS INSIDE THE OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES ONLY · TRANSFERRING THE FILTER TO SCHEDULED CASTE OR SCHEDULED TRIBE

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
LIMB 1 STATUS — notified parental service and status categories exclude the applicant	EXCLUSIONS — salary income and agricultural-land income are not simply clubbed in	ERROR — transferring the filter to Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe reservation
LIMB 2 INCOME — ceiling of ₹8 lakh applied over three consecutive years	SCOPE — the filter runs inside the other backward classes only	LIMB 1 STATUS — notified parental service and status categories exclude the applicant

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- LIMB 1 STATUS — notified parental service and status categories exclude the applicant
- LIMB 2 INCOME — ceiling of ₹8 lakh applied over three consecutive years

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- EXCLUSIONS — salary income and agricultural-land income are not simply clubbed in
- SCOPE — the filter runs inside the other backward classes only

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- ERROR — transferring the filter to Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe reservation
- LIMB 1 STATUS — notified parental service and status categories exclude the applicant

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ERROR — transferring the filter to Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe reservation.

05 AMENDMENT AND JUDGMENT SEQUENCE

STAGE 05 · AMENDMENT AND JUDGMENT SEQUENCE · INDRA SAWHNEY UPHOLDS 27 PER CENT, MANDATES CREAMY LAYER · 102ND AMENDMENT INSERTS ARTICLE 338B AND ARTICLE 342A; THE · 103RD AMENDMENT INSERTS ARTICLE 15(6) AND ARTICLE 16(6) FOR · MARATHA RESERVATION READING CENTRALISES LIST-MAKING; 105TH AMENDMENT RESTORES STATES · JANHIT ABHIYAN UPHOLDS THE ECONOMIC CRITERION BY A MAJORITY

1992 — Indra Sawhney upholds 27 per cent, mandates creamy layer, states the 50 per → 2018 — 102nd Amendment inserts Article 338B and Article 342A; the 1993 Act is repealed → 2019 — 103rd Amendment inserts Article 15(6) and Article 16(6) for economic weakness → 2021 — Maratha reservation reading centralises list-making; 105th Amendment restores States → 2022 — Janhit Abhiyan upholds the economic criterion by a majority of three to two

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- 1992 → Indra Sawhney upholds 27 per cent, mandates creamy layer, states the 50 per cent ceiling
- 2018 → 102nd Amendment inserts Article 338B and Article 342A; the 1993 Act is repealed

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- 2019 → 103rd Amendment inserts Article 15(6) and Article 16(6) for economic weakness
- 2021 → Maratha reservation reading centralises list-making; 105th Amendment restores States

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- 2022 → Janhit Abhiyan upholds the economic criterion by a majority of three to two
- 1992 → Indra Sawhney upholds 27 per cent, mandates creamy layer, states the 50 per cent ceiling

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: 2022 — Janhit Abhiyan upholds the economic criterion by a majority of three to two.

06 ECONOMIC-CRITERION CARD

STAGE 06 · ECONOMIC-CRITERION CARD · DEPARTMENT OF PERSONNEL AND TRAINING NOTIFICATION DATED 31 JANUARY · GROSS ANNUAL FAMILY INCOME BELOW ₹8 LAKH · FAMILY MUST NOT OWN FIVE ACRES OR MORE OF · NO RESIDENTIAL FLAT OF 1,000 SQ FT OR MORE · NO PLOT OF 100 SQ YARDS IN A NOTIFIED

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
NOTIFIED — Department of Personnel and Training notification dated 31 January 2019	LAND — family must not own five acres or more of agricultural land	PLOT — no plot of 100 sq yards in a notified municipality or 200 sq yards elsewhere
INCOME — gross annual family income below ₹8 lakh	BUILT — no residential flat of 1,000 sq ft or more	NOTIFIED — Department of Personnel and Training notification dated 31 January 2019

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- NOTIFIED — Department of Personnel and Training notification dated 31 January 2019
- INCOME — gross annual family income below ₹8 lakh

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- LAND — family must not own five acres or more of agricultural land
- BUILT — no residential flat of 1,000 sq ft or more

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- PLOT — no plot of 100 sq yards in a notified municipality or 200 sq yards elsewhere
- NOTIFIED — Department of Personnel and Training notification dated 31 January 2019

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: PLOT — no plot of 100 sq yards in a notified municipality or 200 sq yards elsewhere.

07 SAME FIGURE, DIFFERENT TEST

STAGE 07 · SAME FIGURE, DIFFERENT TEST · CREAMY LAYER · ₹8 LAKH SINCE SEPTEMBER 2017; THREE CONSECUTIVE YEARS · NOTIFIED PARENTAL SERVICE AND STATUS CATEGORIES; SALARY AND LAND · ECONOMIC CRITERION · ₹8 LAKH SINCE JANUARY 2019; GROSS ANNUAL FAMILY INCOME · NOTIFIED LAND, FLAT AND PLOT ASSET LIMITS, UNCHANGED SINCE · IDENTICAL ARITHMETIC PROVES NOTHING ABOUT IDENTICAL ELIGIBILITY

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
CREAMY LAYER — ₹8 lakh since September 2017; three consecutive years	ECONOMIC CRITERION — ₹8 lakh since January 2019; gross annual family income	RULE — identical arithmetic proves nothing about identical eligibility
PLUS — notified parental service and status categories; salary and land income excluded	PLUS — notified land, flat and plot asset limits, unchanged since 2019	CREAMY LAYER — ₹8 lakh since September 2017; three consecutive years

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- CREAMY LAYER — ₹8 lakh since September 2017; three consecutive years
- PLUS — notified parental service and status categories; salary and land income excluded

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- ECONOMIC CRITERION — ₹8 lakh since January 2019; gross annual family income
- PLUS — notified land, flat and plot asset limits, unchanged since 2019

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- RULE — identical arithmetic proves nothing about identical eligibility
- CREAMY LAYER — ₹8 lakh since September 2017; three consecutive years

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE — identical arithmetic proves nothing about identical eligibility.

08 JUDGMENT SPLIT

STAGE 08 · JUDGMENT SPLIT · RESERVATION FOR ECONOMICALLY WEAKER SECTIONS IS CONSTITUTIONALLY VALID · AN ECONOMIC CRITERION ALONE CAN GROUND AFFIRMATIVE ACTION · EXCEEDING THE CEILING FOR A NEW CATEGORY DOES NOT · EXCLUDING THE RESERVED CATEGORIES FROM A NEW BENEFIT DENIES · THREE TO TWO, SO THE DISAGREEMENT IS PART OF

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- HELD → reservation for economically weaker sections is constitutionally valid
- MAJORITY → an economic criterion alone can ground affirmative action

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- MAJORITY → exceeding the ceiling for a new category does not breach the basic structure
- DISSENT → excluding the reserved categories from a new benefit denies substantive equality

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- MARGIN → three to two, so the disagreement is part of the holding's meaning
- HELD → reservation for economically weaker sections is constitutionally valid

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: MARGIN — three to two, so the disagreement is part of the holding's meaning.

09 DISTRIBUTION PROBLEM

STAGE 09 · DISTRIBUTION PROBLEM · 27 PER CENT FOR THE OTHER BACKWARD CLASSES AS · CONCENTRATION OF BENEFIT IN RELATIVELY ADVANCED COMMUNITIES WITHIN THE · SUB-CATEGORISATION OF THE QUOTA AMONG SUB-GROUPS · EXAMINED BY · THE COMMISSION SET UP IN 2017; IMPLEMENTATION PENDING AS · BACKWARDNESS AND REPRESENTATION DATA FOR EACH SUB-GROUP

QUOTA — 27 per cent for the other backward classes as a single undivided block

OBSERVED — concentration of benefit in relatively advanced communities within the block → PROPOSAL — sub-categorisation of the quota among sub-groups → EXAMINED BY — the commission set up in 2017; implementation pending as of mid-2026

SOCIAL STRUCTURE / CONCEPT
- QUOTA → 27 per cent for the other backward classes as a single undivided block
- OBSERVED → concentration of benefit in relatively advanced communities within the block

MECHANISM OF CHANGE
- PROPOSAL → sub-categorisation of the quota among sub-groups
- EXAMINED BY → the commission set up in 2017; implementation pending as of mid-2026

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
- REQUIREMENT → backwardness and representation data for each sub-group
- QUOTA → 27 per cent for the other backward classes as a single undivided block

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: REQUIREMENT — backwardness and representation data for each sub-group.

10 DATA GAP

STAGE 10 · DATA GAP · LAST PUBLISHED ALL-CASTE TABLES · SOCIO-ECONOMIC AND CASTE CENSUS 2011 · CASTE DATA NEVER RELEASED OR VALIDATED FOR POLICY · CABINET COMMITTEE ON POLITICAL AFFAIRS, 30 APRIL 2025, TO · ALL-DIGITAL 2027 CENSUS; HOUSELISTING NOTIFIED 1 APRIL TO 30 · AN APPROVED OPERATION IS NOT A PUBLISHED DATASET AND

LAST PUBLISHED ALL-CASTE TABLES — 1931

SOCIO-ECONOMIC AND CASTE CENSUS 2011 — caste data never released or validated for policy → DECISION — Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs, 30 April 2025, to enumerate caste → OPERATION — all-digital 2027 Census; houselisting notified 1 April to 30 September 2026

OFFICIAL EVIDENCE / DATE
- LAST PUBLISHED ALL-CASTE TABLES → 1931
- SOCIO-ECONOMIC AND CASTE CENSUS 2011 → caste data never released or validated for policy

WHAT IT PROVES
- DECISION → Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs, 30 April 2025, to enumerate caste
- OPERATION → all-digital 2027 Census; houselisting notified 1 April to 30 September 2026

CLAIM LIMIT
- BOUNDARY → an approved operation is not a published dataset and validates no formula
- LAST PUBLISHED ALL-CASTE TABLES → 1931

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: BOUNDARY — an approved operation is not a published dataset and validates no formula.

11 ENTRY AGAINST CONVERSION

STAGE 11 · ENTRY AGAINST CONVERSION · RESERVATION SLOTS FILLED AND SCHOLARSHIPS DISBURSED IN A REPORTING · FIRST-GENERATION ACCESS · THE FIRST FAMILY MEMBER REACHING HIGHER EDUCATION OR SERVICE · THE NEXT GENERATION EXCEEDING THE BENEFICIARY IN EDUCATION AND · CHILDREN RE-ACCESSING THE SAME RESERVATION WITHOUT PROGRESSION · NO MAINS OR OBJECTIVE DEMAND IS ROUTED HERE AND

COVERAGE — reservation slots filled and scholarships disbursed in a reporting year → FIRST-GENERATION ACCESS — the first family member reaching higher education or service → MOBILITY — the next generation exceeding the beneficiary in education and occupation → STAGNATION — children re-accessing the same reservation without progression → OWNERSHIP — no Mains or objective demand is routed here and none is manufactured

SOCIAL UNIT / DEFINITION
- COVERAGE → reservation slots filled and scholarships disbursed in a reporting year
- FIRST-GENERATION ACCESS → the first family member reaching higher education or service

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
- MOBILITY → the next generation exceeding the beneficiary in education and occupation
- STAGNATION → children re-accessing the same reservation without progression

EXAM TRAP / LIMIT
- OWNERSHIP → no Mains or objective demand is routed here and none is manufactured
- COVERAGE → reservation slots filled and scholarships disbursed in a reporting year

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: OWNERSHIP — no Mains or objective demand is routed here and none is manufactured.

E SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

EXTRA · OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · NCBC (CONSTITUTIONAL BODY, POST-2018) · EXAMINES INCLUSION/EXCLUSION REQUESTS · ROHINI COMMISSION (2017) · SET UP TO EXAMINE SUB-CATEGORISATION OF OBCS WITHIN · EWS INCOME/ASSET CRITERIA · DEFINED BY A DOPT NOTIFICATION DATED 31 JANUARY · EWS CERTIFICATE VERIFICATION CHALLENGE

OPTIONAL RIGHTS AND CAPABILITY DEPTH
- NCBC (constitutional body, post-2018): Examines inclusion/exclusion requests,
- Rohini Commission (2017): Set up to examine sub-categorisation of OBCs within
- EWS income/asset criteria: Defined by a DoPT notification dated 31 January
- CAUTION: EWS certificate verification challenge: Unlike caste certificates (linked to

INDICATOR, ROUND AND STATUS LIMIT
- CAUTION: A dominant OBC community in a state may capture a disproportionate share of OBC
- CAUTION: An EWS applicant with undocumented informal-sector income may fail to obtain a
- CAUTION: The Janhit Abhiyan majority (3-2) upheld EWS reservation on the ground that economic
- CAUTION: Creamy-layer threshold lag: The income ceiling is revised periodically but often

COMPARATIVE WELFARE-DESIGN NUANCE
- CAUTION: EWS excludes SC/ST/OBC: By definition, EWS reservation is for non-SC/ST/OBC
- CAUTION: Data blindness: Without published OBC population data, sub-categorisation is
- CAUTION: Mobility vs coverage: Policy discourse focuses on reservation-slot fill rates
- Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992) upheld OBC reservation up to 27% and mandated

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels